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Never Read a Bible Verse

How (Not) to Read the Bible · Session 1 · Oct 4, 2026 · @Eric

Video notes

Jot down what stands out as you watch.

Why should we "never read a Bible verse"?

An example of a verse taken out of context:

The Bible was written _____ us, but not _____ us. What does that mean?

The Bible's big story in four words: _____ → _____ → _____ → _____

One question the video raised for me:

The method

A verse means what its author meant in its context. Use this every week of the series.

Three circles of context (inside out)

Circle	Ask
Literary	What's in the paragraph and book around it? What kind of writing is it?

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Circle	Ask
Historical	Who wrote it, to whom, when, and what were they going through?
Big story	Where does it fit in Creation → Fall → Redemption → Restoration? How does it point to Jesus?

Three steps (always in this order)

1. **Observe:** What does it say? Look for who, what, where, when, repeated words, and connectors like *for*, *therefore*, *but*.
2. **Interpret:** What did it mean to the first readers? What timeless truth about God and people does it teach?
3. **Apply:** How should that truth change what I believe, love, or do this week?

Workshop

Passage 1: Philippians 4:10–20

Before you start: Write what you've always thought Philippians 4:13 means.

Observe

1. Why is Paul writing this paragraph? (Look at verses 10, 14–18.)
2. Where is Paul as he writes? (Hint: Philippians 1:7, 13.)
3. Verse 12 lists the "all things." What are they?
4. What word in verse 11 sums up what Paul has learned?

Interpret

5. In context, what is the "all things" Christ strengthens Paul to do?
6. Finish the sentence: *The timeless truth here is that Christ's strength...*

Apply

7. Is this verse more or less encouraging in context? Why?

Passage 2: Jeremiah 29:1-14

Before you start: Write what you've always thought Jeremiah 29:11 means.

Observe

1. Who wrote this letter, and to whom? (Verse 1.) Where are they living?
2. What does God tell them to do in verses 5-7? Does that sound like a quick rescue?
3. How long until God's promise is fulfilled? (Verse 10.)
4. What were the false prophets saying? (Verses 8-9.)

Interpret

5. Who is the "you" in verse 11? One person or a whole people?
6. Finish the sentence: *The timeless truth here is that God...*

Apply

7. If a friend posted Jeremiah 29:11 before a big job interview, how would you gently share what you learned tonight?

The verse alone seemed to say...	The verse in context says...
Philippians 4:13:	
Jeremiah 29:11:	

This week

My application: Which verse have I leaned on without ever reading its chapter?

Take-home practice: Pick one and work through it with the three steps.

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- ☐ Matthew 18:15–20 (what is "where two or three are gathered" really about?)
- ☐ Matthew 7:1–5 (does "judge not" mean never make a moral judgment?)
- ☐ The chapter around my own favorite verse

Before next week: Skim Leviticus 19 and note anything that seems strange to you.

"Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law." Psalm 119:18 (ESV)